JOB SEARCH LAUNCHPAD

An AI-guided workbook for emerging architects · about 30–45 minutes
Written by blng studio

The question this workbook helps you answer

What am I actually looking for, and what do I have to work with?

Use this workbook before you rewrite your portfolio or send another application. In three short exercises you take stock of your experience, notice what draws you in, and name what you still need to find out.

A chat assistant helps by asking you questions and organising your answers. It doesn't write applications for you, and it doesn't decide for you. You do the thinking; the workbook keeps the record.

By the end you'll have

- **What you have to work with:** a plain snapshot of your projects, experience, interests, feedback and constraints.
- **Two or three possible directions** to explore, written as ideas to test, not decisions.
- **Three questions** you can't answer yet, and **one small next action**.
- All of it on one page: **My starting point** (page 14).

How it works

Step	What you do	Time
Before you start	Read how to use AI here and gather your material	2–3 min
1. Take stock	Notes on page 6, then Prompt 1	8–12 min
2. Notice the patterns	Notes on page 9, then Prompt 2	8–12 min
3. Name what's unclear	Notes on page 12, then Prompt 3	7–10 min
My starting point	Fill in the one-page summary	5 min
Total		**about 30–45 min**

What you need

- Your CV and portfolio, or simply a list of your projects.
- Any feedback you've kept: crit notes, tutor comments, notes from reviews at work.
- A pen, and any chat assistant. The one you already use is fine.
- About 40 minutes when you won't be interrupted.

Before you start: using AI in this workbook

The assistant is a questioning and organising partner. Five rules keep it useful:

- **Clarify, don't perform.** Use it to sharpen your own thinking, not to build an impressive candidate persona.
- **Ask for real examples.** Don't accept vague claims, from the assistant or from yourself.
- **Nothing invented.** If it adds a strength, a skill or an achievement you didn't give it, cross it out.
- **Your voice, your judgement.** You decide what's true and what matters. Rewrite its wording in your own words.
- **Possibilities, not advice.** Any direction it suggests is something to investigate, not career advice.

How to use the prompts

1. Open a new chat in any chat assistant.
2. Copy everything inside the prompt box and paste it in. Replace the text in [square brackets] with your own notes.
3. Answer its questions one at a time. Short, honest answers are fine.
4. Write what's useful back into this workbook. The workbook, not the chat, is your record.
5. Use the same chat for all three prompts if you can, so it keeps your earlier answers. If you start a new chat, paste in what you wrote on the previous page.

Your data and the assistant's answers

Don't paste personal data you're not comfortable sharing, such as your address, phone number, or other people's names and details. You can describe a project without naming the client or the practice.

AI output can be wrong, so check it against what you actually did. If it doesn't sound like you, it isn't finished.

What this workbook doesn't do

It's a first step, not the whole job search: it won't shortlist practices, write applications or messages, map strengths to evidence, plan applications, redesign your portfolio or prepare you for interviews. It shows what you're working with.

TAKE STOCK

Exercise 1 of 3 · about 8–12 minutes

Take stock

Gather your raw material. Don't sort or judge it yet: rough notes are enough, and gaps are fine. You'll paste these notes into Prompt 1 on the next page.

Academic projects

Which projects, and what did you do on each?

Practice experience

Placements, part-time work, and anything outside architecture that taught you something.

Interests

In architecture and around it: topics, building types, ways of working.

Feedback you've had

From tutors, crits, colleagues or reviews. What came up more than once?

Practical constraints

Location, timing, hours, money, or anything else that limits your options.

Exercise 1 of 3 · Take stock

PROMPT 1 · Take stock

Copy everything below this line and paste it into a new chat

I'm an emerging architect at the start of a job search. Before I change my portfolio or CV, I want to take stock of what I have to work with. Please act as a questioning and organising partner, not a writer.

Ask me questions one at a time, and wait for my answer before you ask the next one. Cover five areas: (1) academic projects, (2) practice experience, including placements, part-time work and anything outside architecture, (3) interests, (4) feedback I've had from tutors, colleagues or reviews, (5) practical constraints, such as location, timing, hours or money.

Rules: use only what I tell you. Don't invent or upgrade my experience, skills or achievements. If an answer is vague, ask me for a real example. Don't suggest a niche, a job title or a career direction, and don't write a personal statement.

When we've covered all five areas, organise my answers into a plain snapshot called "Where I am now", with a short list for each area, in my own words where possible. Mark anything I wasn't sure about with a question mark.

Here are my notes to start from: [paste your notes from page 6]

After the chat: check the snapshot against what you actually did, then write your own version here.

Where I am now: what I have to work with

What I'm not sure about yet

Did the snapshot leave anything out, or add anything you didn't say?

NOTICE THE PATTERNS

Exercise 2 of 3 · about 8–12 minutes

Notice the patterns

Look back over your snapshot. Think about specific moments, not whole projects: a stage, a task, a conversation, a drawing.

Which parts of the work did you enjoy most?

When did time go quickly?

Where did you contribute most?

What did others rely on you for?

What do you want to do more of?

What do you want to do less of?

Which of these are really yours?

Mark anything above that is more about what you think employers want than what you want.

Exercise 2 of 3 · Notice the patterns

PROMPT 2 · Notice the patterns

Copy everything below this line and paste it into a new chat

Here is my "Where I am now" snapshot: [paste your snapshot from page 7]. And here are my notes on what I enjoyed and where I contributed most: [paste your notes from page 9].

Help me notice patterns. Ask me questions one at a time about which parts of the work I enjoyed, where I contributed most, and what I want to do more of, or less of.

For each pattern you think you see, quote the evidence from what I've told you and ask me whether it's true. Help me separate what genuinely interests me from my assumptions about what employers want: if something sounds like an assumption, say so and ask me about it. Don't invent strengths, and don't give me career advice.

At the end, suggest two or three possible directions to explore. Write each one as a hypothesis ("I might enjoy … because …"), list the evidence from my own answers, and say what I would need to find out to test it. Keep my wording where you can.

After the chat: keep only the directions you recognise, and write them as ideas to test, not decisions.

Possible direction 1

I might enjoy … because … (your evidence)

Possible direction 2

I might enjoy … because … (your evidence)

Possible direction 3

I might enjoy … because … (your evidence)

What would help me tell whether any of these is right?

NAME WHAT'S UNCLEAR

Exercise 3 of 3 · about 7–10 minutes

Name what's unclear

List what you can't answer yet. Uncertainty is useful here: a clear question is easier to work on than a vague worry. Tick any of these that are true for you, then add your own.

- [ ] What kind of practice would suit me?
- [ ] What is genuinely distinctive about my work?
- [ ] Does my portfolio show what I want to do?
- [ ] How could I find out whether a direction is right for me?

My own questions

What do you keep wondering about your work, your options or the kind of practice you'd fit?

What's getting in the way?

Anything that stops you starting, such as time, confidence or not knowing who to ask.

Exercise 3 of 3 · Name what's unclear

PROMPT 3 · Name what's unclear

Copy everything below this line and paste it into a new chat

Here are my possible directions: [paste your directions from page 10]. And here is what I can't answer yet: [paste your questions from page 12].

Help me name what's still unclear. Ask me questions one at a time about what I can't yet answer about these directions, my work and the kind of practice that would suit me. Then turn my uncertainty into specific questions I could investigate.

Help me choose the three questions that matter most right now. Then suggest one small exploratory action I could take this week, such as asking a former tutor for feedback or revisiting a project. Keep it small and specific.

Don't write applications, messages or outreach for me, don't give me a list of practices to target, and don't make a plan beyond this one action.

After the chat: pick the three questions you most want answered, in your own words.

Question 1

Question 2

Question 3

One small action

What exactly will you do, and by when?

My starting point

Bring it together on one page. Copy from pages 7, 10 and 13, in your own words. Keep this sheet: it's the record of where you are now, and a useful thing to bring to a Portfolio Review Sprint or any conversation about your next step.

Name and date: _____

What I have to work with

projects, experience, interests, feedback, constraints

Possible directions to explore

two or three, written as ideas to test

Three questions to investigate

One small next action

what, and by when

Your next step

You've taken stock. Now you can see what you're working with, what interests you, and where you need help.

If one of your questions is about your portfolio, whether it shows the work you want to do, what to lead with, or what's missing, a second pair of eyes can help.

Portfolio Review Sprint

A 30-minute video call with Ariadna López Bieling, Principal of blng studio, reviewing the portfolio you already have. You share your screen, go through it together, and come away knowing what to change first. Bring your My starting point sheet.

It's feedback on your portfolio, not a guarantee of a job.

Find out more and book: sprint.blng.studio/sprints/portfolio-review-sprint/

What I'd like feedback on

Useful for a review call, or for asking a former tutor.

About this workbook

This workbook helps you reflect and organise your thinking. It isn't careers advice, and the directions you write down are possibilities to investigate, not decisions. If you use a chat assistant, don't paste personal data you're not comfortable sharing, and check what it gives you: AI output can be wrong.

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